state capital. Saffron paint and BJP leaders replaced the more neutral colouring and older images of former prime minister Manmohan Singh and Sonia Gandhi in 2017 after Yogi Adityanath came to power as the head of the first BJP-majority government in UP in almost two decades. The Election Commission had ordered that the political imagery on the gateway be whitewashed during the 2019 polls. But, once the polls were over, the smiling saffron icons were back—typical of the aggressive political intent of the ruling party and the scale of the new BJP's ambition.

Few places in India, after all, are as emblematic of the Gandhi family and the Congress as Raebareli, a small town 63 kilometres south-east of Lucknow. It is the parliamentary constituency of the Congress matriarch Sonia Gandhi. The seat was first won for the party in India's inaugural democratic national election of 1952 by her father-in-law Feroze Gandhi. It later became the electoral home of her mother-in-law, former prime minister Indira Gandhi. The Congress might have virtually disappeared from the electoral map of Uttar Pradesh from the 1990s onwards, with the rise of regional caste-based parties like the Samajwadi Party and Bahujan Samaj Party, but it has never lost its parliamentary bastion of Raebareli after Sonia became party leader in 1998.

The Gandhi family's other UP bastion of Amethi, parliamentary home to Sonia Gandhi's son, Rahul, was famously lost in 2019. Amethi, which was initially wrested from the BJP's Sanjay Sinh by Sonia Gandhi in 1999, has been won by non-Congress candidates only thrice since 1967. It will be a symbolic prize-catch again in 2024. This is why the emergence of the Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Dwar at the gates of Raebareli itself is so deeply significant. For the Congress, it is an attack right on its homestead. For the BJP, it signifies an assertive new brand of total politics, an in-your-face aggression that takes no prisoners.

Opposition leaders have so far put their hopes in an 'anti-BJPism' counter-force. Like anti-Congressism earlier, this is predicated on the idea that, even at its height, the ruling party does not win more than 40 per cent of the vote share, and therefore, the coming together of anti-BJP forces (what psephologists measure as the index of Opposition unity) can beat it. This was the basis of the